FIFA World Cup 2026 Predictor

Academic Methodology Brief - Training Data & Methods

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Summary. We train on international A-team matches only (country vs country), using a 5-year rolling window before each World Cup cutoff. Recent matches are upweighted (2-year half-life decay), not excluded. The model does not use club football (Premier League, Champions League, etc.).

Data sources

- Historical training: Kaggle martj42 international results (results.csv).
- 2026 fixtures: FIFA.com official schedule/PDF; playoff slots from UEFA/FIFA results.
- DataCamp files: competition submission format only (match_id, schema, placeholder labels) - not schedule authority.
- Optional cross-checks: OpenFootball or TheStatsAPI vs FIFA schedule.

What matches are included?

- Training rows: Kaggle martj42 results.csv. Teams are nations, never clubs.
- Included: WC/continental qualifiers and finals, Nations League, Gold Cup, friendlies, all confederations.
- Excluded: Domestic leagues, UEFA club competitions, matches on/after cutoff, matches older than 5 years.
- Validation: Walk-forward 2018 (tune) and 2022 (holdout); 64 WC finals held out per year.

Training windows (verified counts)

Run	Cutoff	Matches	From	To
2018 development	2018-06-14	4,617	2013-06-15	2018-06-12
2022 confirmation	2022-11-20	4,473	2017-11-22	2022-11-19
2026 production	2026-06-11	5,239	2021-06-12	2026-06-05

Club vs national team

NOT in data: PSG/Arsenal club matches, Premier League, Champions League, club-to-nation mapping.

IN data: France vs Brazil, England vs Germany. UEFA in code means national-team Euro, qualifiers, Nations League.

Match weighting (Iteration 7)

Component	Setting	Meaning
Time decay	2-year half-life	Recent matches weighted highest within 5-year window
Tournament tier	A=1.0 B=0.85 C=0.5	Qualifiers/finals vs Nations League vs friendlies
Opponent difficulty	D_opp	Discount goals vs weak opponents
Competition context	C_conf (Opta-inspired)	FIFA 1.05, UEFA 1.0, CAF 0.88, AFC 0.80

Why Monte Carlo simulation?

Dixon-Coles Poisson yields match-level score probabilities, not tournament-stage outcomes. The 2026 format: 12 groups of four, eight best-third qualifiers into predetermined knockout slots, and a 32-team bracket with slot dependencies on group results.

- Bracket dependencies: knockout pairings follow group standings and best-third tiebreaks; no closed-form winner probability.
- Quantities estimated: P(win), P(reach semifinals), group advancement, best-third qualification uncertainty.
- Method: 10,000 independent simulated tournaments sample Poisson scores, apply FIFA tiebreak rules, aggregate outcomes.

Opta-inspired weights vs OPTA benchmark

IN TRAINING: C_conf multipliers on each match by tournament confederation context (Opta-inspired index).

BENCHMARK ONLY: OPTA pre-tournament win % from CSV - never fed into training.

Backtest (Brier - lower is better)

2018	0.739	Development / tuning
2022	0.726	Holdout confirmation

Iteration 8 (prototype)

Exploratory branch: Transfermarkt squad-value priors blended with walk-forward Elo. Production remains iteration 7; iteration 8 kept for sensitivity analysis only.

Project: fifa_2026_predictor | Training: results.csv | Fixtures: FIFA official schedule | Live: fifa2026-chandra.netlify.app | See Executive_Report.html for full predictions.